Topic 10 — Ancient Indian History Related to Culture

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Ancient Indian Art | Ancient Indian Sculpture | Ancient Indian Architecture | Ancient Indian Agriculture | Ancient Indian Industries

Sources: NCERT An Introduction to Indian Art (Class 11), Themes I, UPPCS Prelims 2018–2025 **Last verified:** August 2026

Current Affairs

- **Mandi** and **Hulas** are Indus sites in Uttar Pradesh. **Rakhigarhi** (राखीगढ़ी) is in Haryana.
- **Dholavira** (धोलावीरा) entered the UNESCO World Heritage list in **2021**.
- **Sarnath** (सारनाथ) entered the UNESCO World Heritage list in **2026**.

10.1 Ancient Indian Art

Ancient art runs from prehistoric rock painting to the Gupta age. Learn each site with its period and medium.

- **Bhimbetka** (MP) is famous for prehistoric rock paintings of animals and hunters. It is a UNESCO site. It is not a Gupta temple.
- The first Indian archaeologist to establish Bhimbetka's prehistoric importance was **V.S. Wakankar**.
- Harappan art is craft-heavy: seals, terracotta, beads and painted pottery. It is not only "religion."
- **Steatite seals** show a unicorn or humped bull plus undeciphered script. They served as trade and identity marks.
- The **terracotta mother goddess** is a Harappan staple. It is distinct from the later stone Yakshi.
- IVC used wheel-thrown painted pottery. Brick was standardised and burnt.
- **Northern Black Polished Ware (NBPW)** is Mauryan elite glossy pottery. It is not Harappan.
- Ajanta mural cycle peaks under **Gupta–Vakataka** (5th–6th c.). The paintings show Jataka scenes in tempera on dry plaster, not Italian fresco.
- UP art centres include **Mathura**, **Sarnath**, **Ahichhatra** (terracotta) and **Kaushambi**.
- Ashoka's cultural staff were the **Dhamma-mahamatras** (धम्म महामात्र), appointed in the **14th** year of coronation. Some papers tie his Dhamma wording to the *Rahulovada-sutta*.

Logic: Bhimbetka = Wakankar + prehistoric. NBPW = Maurya. Seals = steatite**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2020, Q10

Which of the following Indian Archaeologists first visited 'Bhimbetka Caves' and discovered prehistoric significance of its rock paintings?

A. Madho Swaroop Vatsa B. H.D. Sankalia C. V.S. Wakankar D. V.N. Mishra

Show answer

Ans: C — V.S. Wakankar.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2024, Q20

Consider the following statements with respect to Ashoka:

1. The definition of Dhamma given by Ashoka is taken from "Rahulovada-sutta".
2. In the 14th year of his coronation, Ashoka appointed a new type of staff, called Dhamma-mahamatras.

A. Both 1 and 2 B. Neither 1 nor 2 C. Only 1 D. Only 2

Show answer

Ans: A — Both 1 and 2. Mauryan cultural-policy fact.

10.2 Ancient Indian Sculpture

- **Mauryan** sculpture uses Chunar sandstone. It has a mirror polish and animal capitals.
- The **Sarnath Lion Capital** has four addorsed lions. It became the National Emblem in **1950**. It is in **Uttar Pradesh.
- The **Didarganj Yakshi** has Mauryan polish. It is at Patna and is stone, not bronze.
- **Bharhut** has Shunga narrative railings. They show early Buddhist stories in relief.
- **Sanchi** toranas are mature Shunga–Satavahana narrative gateways. They stand in MP.
- **Gandhara sculpture uses grey** schist** (also stucco). The Buddha is Greco-Roman / Hellenistic, with wavy hair, drapery and an Apollo-like face. The school is in the NW (Peshawar–Taxila belt).
- **Mathura** sculpture uses **red sandstone**. It shows an indigenous Buddha and Jina. The centre is in **Uttar Pradesh** (उत्तर प्रदेश), peaking under the Kushans and continuing into the Gupta age.
- **Amaravati** (अमरावती) sculpture uses white / greenish **limestone**. It is from Andhra and shows dynamic narrative and movement.
- Stupas of the Amaravati school and Andhra region (such as Amaravati and Nagarjunakonda) are uniquely distinguished by rectangular platforms bearing groups of five **Aryaka pillars** (*ayaka-stambhas*) at the cardinal points.
- **Gupta / Sarnath** sculpture is the classical ideal. It shows transparent drapery and the **Dharmachakra mudra** (धर्मचक्र मुद्रा) Buddha.
- Terracotta sculpture is huge at **Ahichhatra** and Kaushambi (UP). It is not a “stone school.”

> **Logic:** Mathura = red sandstone, UP. Gandhara = grey schist, Greco-Roman. Amaravati = limestone +

> Aryaka-pillars**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q80

In which of the following stupas are the features of a platform with **'Aryaka-Pillars'** found?

A. Nagarjunakonda B. Ghantasala C. Amaravati D. Bodhgaya

Show answer

Ans: C — Amaravati.

10.3 Ancient Indian Architecture

Ancient architecture runs from the Indus city to Mauryan Buddhist work and the first Gupta temples. There is no true arch in this span.

- **IVC cities** had grid streets, a citadel and lower town, burnt brick and **covered drains**.
- The **Great Bath** is at **Mohenjo-daro**. It is a watertight tank. It is not Harappa's headline fact and not at Varanasi.
- **Lothal** (लोथल) had a dockyard in Gujarat. Terracotta boat models are found there.
- Boat figures and models come from **Mohenjo-daro** and **Lothal**.
- **Dholavira** is known for reservoirs and water management. It is in Gujarat and became UNESCO-listed in **2021**.
- **Kalibangan** (कालीबंगा) is in Rajasthan. It has ploughed-field evidence (agriculture overlap) and fire altars.
- UP Harappan sites include **Alamgirpur** (Meerut), **Hulas** (Saharanpur) and **Mandi** (Muzaffarnagar). **Alamgirpur** is the **easternmost**.
- **Rakhigarhi** is in **Haryana**. It is the largest Indian IVC site. It is **not** in UP.
- **Manda** is in Jammu & Kashmir (northern edge). **Padri** is in Gujarat. **Balu** is in Haryana.
- **Sanauli** (Baghpat, UP) is a late Harappan / OCP chariot burial. It is not a substitute for Alamgirpur in "easternmost" questions.
- **Ashoka pillars** are monolithic with Mauryan polish. Megasthenes describes a wooden palace at Pataliputra.
- **Barabar** caves are in Bihar. They are the earliest surviving rock-cut caves, given by **Ashoka / Dasharatha** to the **Ajivikas** (आजीविक). They are not Chandragupta's donation card.
- The Buddhist trio is the **stupa** (relic mound), **chaitya** (prayer hall) and **vihara** (विहार) (monastery).
- The **Gupta** age sees the first Hindu **structural** temples. The **Dashavatara** (दशावतार) temple is at **Deogarh** (MP). **Bhitargaon** is a brick temple (**Kanpur district, UP**).
- Pre-Islamic spans use **corbel**, not the true radiating arch.

> **Logic:** Mandi + Hulas = UP. Rakhigarhi ≠ UP. Alamgirpur = eastern boundary**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2025, Q87

Which of the following archaeological sites related to the Indus Valley Civilization are situated in present-day Uttar Pradesh?

1. Mandi
2. Rakhigarhi
3. Hulas

A. 1 and 2 B. Only 3 C. 1 and 3 D. Only 1

Show answer

Ans: C — 1 and 3. Mandi and Hulas = UP. Rakhigarhi = Haryana.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2023, Q28

The eastern boundary of the Harappan culture is indicated by which of the following?

A. Harappa B. Alamgirpur C. Rakhigarhi D. Manda

Show answer

Ans: B — Alamgirpur (Meerut, UP). Manda = northern (J&K). Rakhigarhi = Haryana.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2022, Q68

From which archaeological site of the Indus Valley Civilization are figures or models of boats found?

A. Dholavira and Bhagatrav B. Harappa and Kot Diji C. Mohenjo-daro and Lothal D. Kalibangan and Ropar

Show answer

Ans: C — Mohenjo-daro and Lothal.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2021, Q100

In which State of India is the Harappan Civilization site Mandi situated?

A. Gujarat B. Haryana C. Rajasthan D. Uttar Pradesh

Show answer

Ans: D — Uttar Pradesh.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2020, Q12

Match List-I with List-II.

List-I (Harappan Site) A. Balu B. Manda C. Padri D. Hulas

List-II (UT/State) 1. Uttar Pradesh 2. Jammu & Kashmir 3. Haryana 4. Gujarat

A. 3 2 1 4 B. 2 3 4 1 C. 2 4 3 1 D. 3 2 4 1

Show answer

Ans: D — 3 2 4 1. Balu Haryana, Manda J&K, Padri Gujarat, Hulas UP.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q88

Which of the following centres related to Indus Valley are situated in Uttar Pradesh?

I. Kalibanga II. Lothal III. Alamgirpur IV. Hulas

A. I, II, III, IV B. I, II C. II, III D. III, IV

Show answer

Ans: D — III, IV. Kalibangan = Rajasthan. Lothal = Gujarat.

10.4 Ancient Indian Agriculture

Ancient agriculture runs from the Indus urban food base to the Vedic plough village and the Mauryan state farm.

- IVC staples were **wheat** and **barley**. Sesamum, mustard and dates were also grown.
- **Cotton** cultivation and textile evidence begin in the IVC. Cotton is not a colonial crop.
- Terracotta **plough** models are known. The wooden plough had a simple share.
- **Kalibangan** preserves a **ploughed field**.
- Granaries in citadels (Harappa, Mohenjo-daro) indicate surplus storage.
- Irrigation used river flood and **wells**. Dholavira shows planned water storage.
- **Rigvedic** society is mainly **pastoral**. Cattle counted as wealth.
- **Later Vedic** society is more **agrarian**. Rice (*vrihi*) grows in the eastern Gangetic belt.
- The Mauryan state treats agriculture as the revenue base. The *Arthashastra* records land measure and irrigation officers.
- Iron tools (axe, sickle) spread widely by the Mauryan age and after. Forest clearance opens new fields.
- Gupta copper-plate **land grants** are known. Inscriptions record tanks and wells. Faxian notes a prosperous countryside.
- Maize, potato and tobacco are **New World**. They are not IVC crops.

> **Logic:** IVC economy = **wheat + barley + cotton. Rigvedic** society is **pastoral. Later Vedic** society turns **agrarian**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2020, Q21

Match List-I with List-II.

List-I A. Indus Valley Civilization B. Later Vedic Society C. Rigvedic Society D. Medieval Period

List-II 1. Pastoral 2. Landlordism 3. Agrarian 4. Urban

A. 4 2 3 1 B. 2 1 4 3 C. 3 4 1 2 D. 4 3 1 2

Show answer

Ans: D — 4 3 1 2. IVC urban, Later Vedic agrarian, Rigvedic pastoral, Medieval landlordism.

10.5 Ancient Indian Industries

Ancient industries are specialised crafts from Harappan workshops to Gupta guilds.

- **Chanhudaro** was a bead factory. Materials include carnelian, faience and steatite.
- Shell bangles come from coastal Harappan sites (Nageshwar, Balakot).
- The **Dancing Girl** is **bronze**, made by **lost-wax (cire perdue)**, from Mohenjo-daro. It is not terracotta and not stone.
- IVC used copper–bronze tools. Gold and silver jewellery is also known.
- **Iron** becomes a mass tool-metal by Mauryan times. Pillars remain stone.
- **Wootz** is South Indian crucible steel. It had export fame (later "Damascus" raw).
- Cotton textiles are known from IVC onward. Indian cotton was known in Roman trade.
- Silk references thicken in Mauryan–Gupta texts. The *Arthashastra* knows silk cloth.
- **NBPW** is a Mauryan pottery industry, not a metal.
- **Punch-marked** coins run from the janapadas into the **Maurya** age. They are irregular silver/copper with symbols.
- **Gupta gold dinaras** are die-struck. Types show the king with Lakshmi or as an archer.
- A **sreni** was an ancient craft and merchant **guild**. It was regulated in the *Arthashastra*. Gupta inscriptions show guild donations.
- A **nagaram** (नगरम) was a town merchant assembly in the South.
- **Nanadesis** were itinerant merchants of "many countries."
- **Manigrama** (मणिग्रामम) was a South Indian merchant guild with long-distance / overseas trade.

> **Logic:** Beads = Chanhudaro. Dancing Girl = bronze. Punch-marked ≠ Gupta gold. Sreni ≠ Nanadesi**.

PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q89

Which of the following institutions belonged to foreign trade?

A. Sreni B. Nagaram C. Nanadesis D. Manigrama

Show answer

Ans: D — Manigrama. South Indian merchant guild with overseas trade. Sreni = general ancient guild. Nagaram = town merchants. Nanadesis = itinerant multi-region traders (close distractor).
